

LISTENING POST Jamaat member Sayar Ahmad Reshi at a roadshow in Kulgam constituency

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J&K POLLS

SEPARATISTS IN THE FRAY

By Moazum Mohammad in Kulgam

Once a hotbed of militancy, Kulgam in south Kashmir has seen a sea change. The enthusiasm for the coming assembly polls is palpable everywhere. On a sunny morning in village Odhura here, a thin security patrol is scanning the eager crowd milling around the main road. They are waiting for Sayar Ahmad Reshi, a 42-year-old MPhil in Political Science and the Kulgam candidate of the banned Jamaat-e-Islami (JeI). In a striking departure from the past, when boycott was the norm, a dozen 'separatists', including Jamaat and Hurriyat Conference leaders, have joined the electoral fray this time. The erudite Reshi is one of them.

The rhetoric, though laced by the usual chants of *'Naare-e-takbeer Allahu Akbar'* and *'Inquilab zindabad'*, is markedly different, too, as Reshi begins his maiden campaign speech. "We are citizens of India and have the same rights as anyone in the country. *Badlaav* (change) has started. I will be the voice of the voiceless, we will prove that there is no one more loyal to India and democracy than us," he says while repeatedly citing the Indian Constitution and the fundamental rights enshrined in it. Incidentally, Reshi's home in Kahrote village was among those raided in February by the National Investigation Agency (NIA) in relation to a terror funding case.

A BAN IMPOSED IN 2019 STILL HOLDS, BUT THE THAW IN JAMAAT'S STANCE ON POLLS COMES AFTER REPORTED "SECRET" TALKS WITH THE CENTRE

Since 1996, the Kulgam seat has been represented by old CPI(M) warhorse M.Y. Tarigami, a phase marked by an absolute abjuration of the poll process by the separatists. Reshi seeks to qualify that stance now. "We (Jamaat) never boycotted the election per se, we were protesting against it being rigged (in 1987)," he says. "I am forced to contest as an Independent. We had planned to contest on our own symbol if they (the Centre) lifted the ban on the Jamaat."

The pro-Pakistan Jamaat and the Jammu and Kashmir Liberation Front (JKLF) led by Yasin Malik were among the several organisations banned for unlawful activities in February 2019. Being the ideological fount of terror outfit Hizbul Mujahideen, the Jamaat has seen a crackdown against its members since then. But the party, which has over 5,000 members, formed a panel in 2022 to deal with its problems, including the ban. The Jamaat reportedly had secret talks with New Delhi, mediated by Apni Party chief Altaf Bukhari, and expressed its willingness to return to electoral politics if the ban was lifted.

The profound shift in the politics of Kashmir is attributed to many factors, including the crackdown on separatists,